Environment and Economy[1]

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[1] Transition to a Plant-based economy policies can be found in a separate policy pack

Urgently addressing Climate Change

The AJP is the only political party in Aotearoa New Zealand with a serious commitment to tackling major sources of emissions in ways which are credible, compassionate and aligned with climate science. We support a rapid reduction in animal agriculture (which is responsible for around half of Aotearoa New Zealand's emissions) by transitioning to a plant-based economy, supporting farmers to grow produce instead of farming animals and addressing the profoundly detrimental impact of climate change on animals. Additionally, animals are extremely vulnerable to the storms, flooding and fires we continue to see in Aotearoa New Zealand as a result of climate change.

We support policies that reduce emissions, avoid unnecessary animal suffering, improve human and non-human animal health, and restore and expand our waterways, forests and wildlife. We reject ineffective solutions that aim to perpetuate the status quo. We are committed to supporting animals of all kinds to adapt to the changes in climate that are already underway, and that which are predicted, in order to create a sustainable future

Core Principle

Climate change is a symptom of the metacrisis, a planetary emergency requiring a whole-of-government response that addresses root causes, not symptoms. We must move beyond the failed approach of leaving token climate action to environment ministries while economic policy continues business-as-usual. This systemic approach protects animals by preventing the habitat destruction, ocean acidification, extreme weather events, and ecosystem collapse driven by climate change, while ending the economic pressures that force expansion of industrial animal agriculture and fossil fuel extraction into remaining wildlife territories.

Climate leadership

The AJP calls for climate leadership that protects sentient beings. Climate change threatens all life in Aotearoa and across the Pacific as well as globally. Effective climate leadership must embed sentient animal protection into all domestic frameworks, working to prevent further climate change while strengthening enforcement and accountability. Climate risk assessments and adaptation plans must explicitly consider the welfare of animals and the health of ecosystems, alongside human infrastructure and communities, ensuring that policy decisions reduce harm and build ecological resilience.

New Zealand has a responsibility to partner with Pacific Island nations as tangata whenua of Te Moana-nui-a-Kiwa. Supporting Pacific-led solutions, including climate-safe migration pathways and sanctuary networks, protects both human and non-human communities.

Ending fossil fuel financing, intensive agriculture, and creating regional climate coalitions ensures biodiversity, marine life and habitats are safeguarded. By linking domestic climate action with regional cooperation, New Zealand can lead in protecting animals, ecosystems and communities from the escalating impacts of climate change.

Key Objectives

1. Enforce robust National Adaptation Plan commitments, with binding timelines and penalties for departments that fail to protect animals and habitats.
2. Extend domestic climate risk assessments to regional impacts, ensuring wildlife, marine ecosystems and nonhuman animals are considered in partnership with Pacific Island nations.
3. Prioritise climate partnerships with Pacific Island nations, recognising their role as tangata whenua and stewards of marine and terrestrial biodiversity.
4. Support Pacific-led solutions to climate displacement, including pathways that protect both human and wildlife communities.
5. Expand climate risk assessments to consider ecological and animal welfare impacts alongside human infrastructure and health.
6. Lead regional coalitions to end fossil fuel financing, intensive agriculture and establish Pacific climate sanctuary networks protecting biodiversity, marine life and ecosystems.

Reducing Climate-Harming Emissions Energy

The AJP recognises that reducing energy demand is the most immediate way to protect animals and ecosystems. Lowering consumption and promoting shared resource solutions reduces pressure on natural habitats, limits pollution and mitigates climate-driven disasters that harm nonhuman animals.

Fossil fuels are a major driver of habitat destruction, pollution and climate change. Urgent action to eliminate fossil fuels and accelerate renewable energy will further safeguard animals while building resilient, community-led energy systems.

Intensive animal agriculture is one of New Zealand's largest sources of greenhouse gas emissions, producing significant methane and nitrous oxide while causing direct suffering to farmed animals. Reducing intensive farming operations addresses both climate impacts and animal welfare.

Transport emissions continue to rise, driven by fossil fuel dependence and ongoing road expansion that fragments wildlife habitats. Shifting to public and active transport reduces emissions while protecting ecosystems from further development pressures.

Key Objectives

1. Reduce overall energy use and promote shared resource solutions, lowering pressure on habitats and animals.
2. Reverse the lifting of the offshore exploration ban and reinstate the moratorium on new fossil fuel permits, preventing habitat destruction and pollution.
3. Phase out existing fossil fuel infrastructure on a strict timeline, cutting emissions and climate-related harm to animals.
4. End government underwriting and tax incentives for fossil fuel exploration, particularly the current government's moves to subsidise offshore oil and gas exploration
5. Set legally binding targets for 100% renewable electricity, reducing greenhouse gas emissions that threaten biodiversity.
6. Fast-track decentralised, community-owned renewable energy projects, compatible with wildlife corridors and urban green spaces.
7. Address emissions from intensive animal farming, see AJP Transition to a plant-based economy policies for comprehensive agriculture reform measures.
8. Accelerate the transition to zero-emission public and active transport.
9. Prioritise rail and public transport infrastructure over new road construction.

Climate Change Adaptation

The AJP calls for sentient animal protection to be embedded at the heart of all climate adaptation, land-use and emergency management decisions to safeguard lives, maintain ecosystem resilience and create communities that thrive for all species.

Climate change is already causing harm to wild living animals, farmed animals and companion animals across Aotearoa. Yet current adaptation and emergency planning prioritises humans, leaving many sentient beings vulnerable to extreme weather, habitat loss and resource scarcity. Protecting animals is an ethical imperative and essential for resilient ecosystems.

Key Objectives

1. Mandate animal protection in all climate adaptation plans, requiring dedicated, funded and measurable chapters on wildlife and domestic/farmed animals.
2. Require Sentient Animal Risk Assessments (SARA) for all major infrastructure and land-use projects, assessing climate-related risks to nearby animal populations and enforcing mitigation strategies.
3. Integrate animal welfare into emergency management, embedding rescue teams, climate-resilient shelters and evacuation protocols for wildlife, farmed and companion animals.
4. Establish rapid-response emergency systems for all nonhuman animals, including flood, fire, drought and storm events, and fund community-based preparedness programs.
5. Create climate refuges and urban wildlife safety networks, including habitat corridors, heat refuges and stormwater management that protects native species.
6. Provide dedicated climate-resilience funding and incentives for initiatives that reduce animal suffering and protect biodiversity during extreme weather events.
7. Fund research and monitoring programs to identify high-risk species and regions, informing climate adaptation and emergency responses.
8. Implement cross-sector coordination mechanisms, linking environmental, agriculture, urban planning and emergency agencies to integrate animal-focused adaptation strategies at all levels.

Protecting Ecosystems and Biodiversity

The AJP envisions a world where ecosystems thrive, and biodiversity flourishes, fostering harmonious coexistence between humans and other animals. We aspire to a future where habitats are safeguarded, species abound, and the delicate balance of our planet's natural systems endures for generations. The undeniable detrimental impact of animal agriculture and the current management of biodiversity and habitats necessitates urgent action.

We advocate for a paradigm shift in agriculture towards efficient and productive land use without farming animals. This not only reduces ecological footprints but also creates opportunities for rewilding farmland, allowing natural ecosystems to flourish, and carbon sequestration. We support compassionate conservation measures, habitat restoration, and the implementation of policies to mitigate the impact of pollutants and pesticides, including ongoing and emerging environmental challenges.

In honouring the Māori worldview, we embrace the concept of Kaitiakitanga, recognising our responsibility as guardians of the land. We look back to traditional practices that emphasise respect for nature and integrate these principles as we seek to preserve biodiversity and also respect the cultural connection between humans, non-human animals and the environment. In doing so, we aim to forge a sustainable path forward, where ecosystems are safeguarded, and the richness of biodiversity is cherished and protected.

Comprehensive Waste Minimisation at Source

The AJP is committed to eliminating waste creation at the source rather than managing waste streams after environmental damage has already occurred. We acknowledge that current approaches focus on end-of-pipe solutions while ignoring the resource extraction and manufacturing processes that destroy wildlife habitats to create products destined to become waste.

Every product manufactured requires raw materials extracted from ecosystems where animals live. Mining operations destroy underground habitats for countless invertebrates and soil organisms as well as the ecosystems at the surface. Forestry operations fragment and destroy territories used by native birds, bats and ground-dwelling species. Manufacturing processes consume enormous quantities of water that animals depend upon whilst generating toxic byproducts that contaminate the environments where wildlife must survive.

The most effective way to protect animal habitats is to dramatically reduce the volume of products manufactured in the first place. When we require manufacturers to design out waste, extend product lifespans and take responsibility for entire product lifecycles, we directly reduce the pressure on natural systems that sustain wildlife populations.

The AJP prioritises eliminating waste at its source to protect wildlife habitats and reduce resource extraction. Every tonne of waste not created avoids trucks driving through wildlife corridors, prevents processing facilities from being built on productive land and keeps disposal sites from contaminating watersheds that native species rely on. By requiring products to be designed for longevity, repairability and responsible end-of-life management, these policies minimise environmental harm while keeping recovery systems as a back-up for what cannot be designed out.

Key Objectives:

1. Ban single-use products where reusable alternatives exist, reducing demand for resource extraction and habitat destruction
2. Mandate modular and repairable product design standards, including minimum lifespan guarantees, spare parts availability, and legal rights to repair, eliminating planned obsolescence.
3. Establish producer responsibility schemes requiring manufacturers to fund collection, processing, and safe disposal of all products they place on the market
4. Impose penalties on companies whose products contaminate ecosystems or cause wildlife mortality, internalising environmental and social costs
5. Require large businesses to report annually on material flows, meet binding waste-reduction targets, and comply with resource efficiency standards

Single-Use Plastic Elimination

The AJP is committed to comprehensive legislation eliminating single-use plastics and implementing circular packaging systems that protect marine life from the devastating impacts of plastic pollution. We acknowledge that current voluntary approaches have failed catastrophically, with New Zealand generating 252,000 tonnes of plastic waste annually[2] whilst marine ecosystems face unprecedented contamination threatening the survival of numerous species.

Plastic pollution kills over one million seabirds and 100,000 marine mammals globally each year.[3] In New Zealand waters, pilot whales, dolphins, and seals regularly die from plastic ingestion whilst microplastics contaminate the entire marine food web. Every piece of single-use plastic produced will persist in the environment for centuries, continuing to fragment into smaller pieces that marine animals cannot avoid consuming.

Current recycling systems are inadequate, with much of New Zealand's plastic waste exported overseas or sent to landfill. Only 9% of all plastic ever produced has been recycled, whilst 12% has been incinerated and 79% remains in landfills or the environment.[4] Voluntary corporate commitments have delivered minimal progress whilst plastic production continues accelerating globally.

Successful legislative approaches demonstrate alternatives work. The EU's Single-Use Plastics Directive banned numerous problematic items whilst Rwanda's plastic bag ban created thousands of jobs in alternative industries. Countries implementing comprehensive plastic reduction policies consistently achieve dramatic pollution reductions whilst fostering innovation in sustainable packaging.

The AJP believes that mandatory single-use plastic elimination is a critical first step in source minimisation. Eliminating unnecessary single-use plastics tackles one of the most harmful and avoidable waste streams, while recovery and reuse systems manage what cannot be avoided. This approach protects marine ecosystems, creates opportunities for innovative packaging solutions, prevents countless plastic-related deaths of marine animals, reduces toxic contamination of seafood, and establishes New Zealand as a global leader in marine protection.

Key Objectives:

1. Ban all non-essential single-use plastics including bags, straws, utensils, and food containers within three years
2. Mandate producer responsibility schemes requiring manufacturers to fund collection and processing of plastic packaging waste
3. Invest in reusable packaging infrastructure and refill systems that eliminate disposable containers

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[2] https://resourcewhanganui.org.nz/resource/1243#:~:text=According%20to%20NZ%20Plastics%20every,recycling%20or%20sending%20to%20landfill

[3] https://www.mbrctheocean.com/pages/shocking-plastic-statistics

[4] https://www.plasticsoupfoundation.org/blog/plastic-production-decomposition/#:~:text=Only%209%25%20of%20that%20plastic,as%20plastic%20does%20not%20decompose

4. Establish plastic-free procurement policies across all government agencies and state-funded institutions
5. Legislate maximum packaging standards requiring manufacturers to use minimal, recyclable, or compostable materials, with mandatory reduction targets and penalties for excessive or non-recyclable packaging

Comprehensive Zero Waste Systems

The AJP is committed to implementing nationwide zero-waste infrastructure that eliminates the environmental degradation caused by landfills and ocean pollution—protecting marine life, native species, and ecosystems from the devastating impacts of waste. We recognise that waste management systems are merely end-of-pipe solutions that address only part of a system-wide problem that needs tackling at the start of the pipe, by reducing waste production in the first place. We acknowledge that current consumer production systems that produce so much waste are failing both our communities and our wildlife, with many councils sending 60-100% of recycling to landfill[5] whilst 4.6 million drink containers are littered or landfilled daily.[6] Much more litter is also uncollected as part of any disposal process or scheme.

Ocean plastic kills over 100,000 marine mammals annually worldwide,[7] whilst poorly managed landfills leach toxins into waterways that native fish and birds depend upon. Every piece of waste that is not produced or avoids landfill or ocean dumping represents habitat preserved and wildlife protected. Container deposit return schemes, successfully operating in 57 countries, achieve recycling rates of 85-95%[8] compared to New Zealand's current 28% for plastic bottles.[9]

Composting systems that work with natural cycles break down organic matter in oxygen-rich conditions, avoiding the methane emissions released when the same material decomposes anaerobically in landfills. They also create soil that supports native plant restoration. When 4.5 million tonnes of soil unnecessarily go to landfill annually,[10] we are literally burying the foundation for ecosystem recovery. Business support for zero-waste models creates employment while reducing the resource extraction that destroys wildlife habitats.

Evidence from Australia shows container deposit systems create thousands of jobs whilst dramatically reducing litter.[11] Germany's comprehensive waste systems achieve 68% recycling rates[12] whilst generating significant economic benefits.[13] These aren't theoretical solutions, they're proven approaches that other jurisdictions use successfully.

The AJP believes that comprehensive zero-waste systems are essential infrastructure for protecting wildlife and creating economic opportunities. By eliminating toxic pollution, reducing habitat destruction from resource extraction and reintegrating unavoidable materials into natural cycles, these systems prevent environmental harm while reinforcing the priority of eliminating waste at its origin and building a circular economy where animals and humans can thrive together.

Key Objectives:

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[5] Vast majority of mixed recycling from public bins ends up in landfill
[6] New research proves a Container Deposit Return Scheme will cut litter and waste fast in New Zealand
[7] Pollution — WWF Protecting Whales & Dolphins Initiative
[8] https://zerowaste.co.nz/container-return-scheme-is-a-climate-solution/
[9] Is transforming recycling enough? | The Spinoff
[10] Viewing soil as a resource, not a waste
[11] Australia Achieves Nationwide Container Deposit Schemes | TOMRA
[12] Waste recycling in Europe | Indicators | European Environment Agency (EEA)
[13] Current status report on the German circular economy published

1. Implement nationwide container deposit return schemes as part of a whole-life cycle approach to consumer goods, eliminating the 4.6 million drink containers currently littered or landfilled daily
2. Develop district-wide composting and soil reuse systems that follow natural nutrient cycles, prevent 4.5 million tonnes of soil from reaching landfills annually, and support native ecosystem restoration
3. Support business networks trialling zero-waste models with targeted funding for ecological business transitions that create employment and reduce habitat destruction
4. Establish national zero-waste infrastructure standards that ensure recovery systems complement, rather than substitute for, source reduction policies

Urban Biodiversity and Natural Infrastructure

The AJP is committed to restoring native ecosystems within urban environments, creating corridors for wildlife movement and habitat regeneration that support both indigenous species and community wellbeing. We acknowledge that urban development has fragmented natural habitats, isolating native species populations and reducing their resilience to climate change and other pressures.

Urban areas house 86% of New Zealand's population[14] but often function as ecological deserts where native wildlife cannot survive or move between remaining habitat patches. Yet cities also represent a great opportunity for rapid biodiversity gains. Urban forests in New Zealand, such as those in Auckland's parks, can sequester carbon at rates comparable to natural vegetation. A study by Schwendenmann and Mitchell (2014) found that a 27-year-old planted forest stored a total of 45.9 megagrams of carbon per hectare, equating to an average annual carbon sequestration rate of 1.7 megagrams per hectare.[15] This rate is within the range reported for New Zealand shrublands. Despite challenges like poor-quality soil and contamination, urban forests can sequester carbon at similar rates to natural vegetation in New Zealand. By providing both carbon storage and connectivity, these forests support biodiversity while contributing to climate mitigation.

Green infrastructure provides multiple benefits: native plantings filter stormwater whilst creating habitat, tree canopy reduces urban heat whilst providing nesting sites, and biodiversity corridors connect fragmented ecosystems whilst offering communities opportunities to engage with native wildlife. Research shows that urban biodiversity supports human mental health[16] whilst creating resilient ecosystems that can adapt to climate change.

International examples demonstrate what's possible. Singapore's "City in a Garden" initiative has transformed dense urban areas into functional habitat networks. Its green corridors and restored parks support over 60 bird species, as well as bats, butterflies, and other native fauna, allowing them to move safely across the city and access feeding and breeding sites.[17] These corridors turn urban spaces from ecological deserts into interconnected habitats that sustain animal populations.

Melbourne's Urban Forest Strategy, which plants over 3,000 trees annually, not only improves air quality and urban resilience but also creates canopy networks and stepping stones that allow native birds, bats, and insects to navigate and survive in the city landscape.[18] By integrating animals' needs into city planning, these initiatives show that urban greening is essential infrastructure for biodiversity, not just human amenity. Uk example

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[14] https://www.statista.com/statistics/455899/urbanization-in-new-zealand/#:~:text=The%20share%20of%20urban%20population,than%20a%20consistent%20upward%20trend

[15] https://newzealandecology.org/nzje/3125

[16] https://wildlife.org/can-biodiversity-boost-mental-health/#:~:text=In%20a%20recent%20study%20published%20in%20Scientific,wellbeing%20compared%20to%20places%20with%20less%20diversity

[17] https://www.nparks.gov.sg/who-we-are/city-in-nature-key-strategies

[18] https://www.melbourne.vic.gov.au/urban-forest-strategy

The AJP believes that urban biodiversity restoration is a critical and achievable step toward creating cities where native species can thrive alongside human communities. This approach will create habitat corridors that support wildlife movement, improve ecosystem resilience against climate change, and provide communities with meaningful opportunities to connect with and care for native species.

Key Objectives:

1. Expand urban tree canopy cover to 40% across all suburban areas, prioritising native species that provide habitat and food sources for indigenous wildlife
2. Establish green corridors connecting fragmented habitats to enable safe movement for native birds, bats, and beneficial insects
3. Transform degraded urban land into thriving native ecosystems through community-led restoration programmes
4. Create accessible parks and green spaces that welcome diverse communities whilst supporting comprehensive biodiversity restoration
5. Maintain a general tree protection policy so that mature, significant and culturally/ecologically important individual and groups of trees are protected by default

Protecting Insects from Human-Caused Harms

Insects, particularly pollinators, are in global decline, with studies showing terrestrial insect abundance dropping by about 9 % per decade.[19] Although long-term monitoring is lacking in New Zealand, around 54 % of assessed native insect species are currently listed as threatened or at risk, underscoring the urgent need for conservation.[20] Habitat loss, monoculture farming, and pesticide use are major drivers of these declines.

There is also growing scientific evidence of sentience of different insects. For example, a 2022 review of the evidence for pain in insects found "strong evidence" for the orders containing flies and cockroaches, "substantial" evidence for the orders containing beetles and butterflies, and "no good evidence that any insects failed a criterion".[21] Since these species are largely under-studied, a precautionary approach requires that we grant protection even when such evidence is incomplete.[22]

Key threats to insects are:

- The expansion of urban areas and intensive farming has led to the destruction of natural habitats, reducing the availability of nesting sites and food sources for many insect species.
- The widespread use of chemical pesticides has had devastating effects on insect populations, particularly bees, butterflies, and other pollinators. Many pesticides disrupt the nervous systems of insects, leading to mass die-offs.
- Industrial agricultural practices, including large-scale monocultures, reduce plant diversity and limit food sources for insects, further contributing to population declines.
- Rising temperatures, shifting weather patterns, and pollution disrupt insect life cycles and reduce the availability of suitable habitats.

Protecting insects is essential for maintaining a thriving environment. AJP will continue to advocate for policies that safeguard pollinators, restore ecosystems and promote sustainable land-use practices.

Key Objectives:

1. Safeguard and restore natural ecosystems, such as forests, meadows, wetlands and waterways, which are vital for the survival of bees, butterflies, and other insects.
2. Implement stricter regulations on pesticide use, including restrictions on high-toxicity chemicals during key insect activity periods, in areas where insects forage, breed, or migrate, and promote adoption of non-toxic alternatives.
3. Support research and development of non-toxic alternatives to chemical pesticides.
4. Promote mixed farming practices over monocultures to enhance habitat diversity and insect-friendly landscapes.

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[19] van Klink, R., Bowler, D. E., Gongalsky, K. B., Swengel, A. B., Gentile, A., & Chase, J. M. (2020). Meta-analysis reveals declines in terrestrial but increases in freshwater insect abundances. *Science*, 368(6489), 417–420. https://doi.org/10.1126/science.aax9931

[20] Barnsley, J. (2021). *Is Aotearoa losing its insects? We don't have the data to say* (Intern report for the Office of the Prime Minister's Chief Science Advisor). Wellington: Department of the Prime Minister and Cabinet. Retrieved from https://www.dpmc.govt.nz/sites/default/files/2024-01/PMCSA-21-10-02-V1-Intern-report-Jono-Sept-2021-final.pdf

[21] Gibbons, M., Crump, A., Barrett, M., Sarlak, S., Birch, J., & Chittka, L. (2022). Can insects feel pain? A review of the neural and behavioural evidence. Advances in insect physiology, 63, 155-229.

[22] Birch, J. (2017). Animal sentience and the precautionary principle. Animal sentience, 2(16), 1.

5. Incentivise farmers and landowners to maintain wildflower corridors, hedgerows and native plant species that provide food and shelter for insects.
6. Develop community-led initiatives to promote planting and conservation of native flora.
7. Integrate pollinator-friendly plants into urban and rural land-use planning, ensuring food sources and safe corridors are widely available.
8. Establish monitoring programs to track insect populations and measure the success of conservation efforts.
9. Introduce educational programs in schools and communities to highlight the importance of insects. *See policy Compassionate Education policy.*
10. Conduct national awareness-raising campaigns on the role of pollinators in maintaining biodiversity and food security.

Strengthening Environmental Enforcement in Aotearoa

The AJP is committed to robust enforcement of environmental protections to ensure industries cannot profit from destroying ecosystems that animals depend on for survival. While New Zealand has an Environmental Protection Authority (EPA), current enforcement and penalties are often inadequate, and monitoring resources are limited. This can result in some companies treating fines as a minor business cost rather than a meaningful deterrent to harmful behaviour.

Weak enforcement allows ongoing degradation of marine habitats, freshwater ecosystems and native wildlife populations. Some companies discharge pollutants, destroy sensitive habitats or operate without full compliance because penalties are too low or violations go undetected. When penalties represent only a small fraction of profits, destructive practices become economically rational. The result is systematic environmental degradation that threatens the survival of native species whilst communities bear the health and economic costs.

International best practice demonstrates effective enforcement works. Countries with strong environmental agencies, substantial penalties and comprehensive monitoring achieve significantly better environmental outcomes. In Germany, the Federal Environment Agency (UBA) imposes substantial fines and criminal penalties for environmental violations, reinforced by public reporting and court decisions emphasizing climate and ecosystem protection.[23] In the Netherlands, environmental authorities enforce a “duty of care,” issuing administrative sanctions and remedial orders to prevent harm, holding both companies and individuals accountable.[24] These approaches show that independent authorities, meaningful penalties, and executive liability significantly improve environmental outcomes.

The AJP believes that robust environmental enforcement is essential for protecting the ecosystems that sustain all life in Aotearoa. Strong enforcement will deter environmental destruction, ensure polluters pay the full costs of their impacts and create market incentives that reward companies protecting rather than exploiting natural systems.

Key Objectives:

1. Strengthen and expand the powers of the New Zealand EPA, enabling immediate stop-work orders and higher penalties for serious environmental violations.
2. Implement penalty structures exceeding potential profits from environmental violations, ensuring harmful activities are never economically rational.
3. Create personal liability provisions making corporate directors and executives criminally responsible for serious environmental crimes
4. Fund comprehensive environmental monitoring systems, including satellite technology, remote sensing and community reporting networks.

[23] https://www.umweltbundesamt.de/en/Node/79061

[24] https://www.nortonrosefulbright.com/en-nl/knowledge/publications/b0c7428d/navigating-the-maze-of-environmental-liabilities

Economic Sufficiency Within Planetary Boundaries

The AJP recognises the profound impact of our lifestyles, economic metrics of success, dietary choices, and leisure activities on the environment. The core issue that urgently needs to be addressed is the current unsustainable trajectory, particularly in terms of environmental degradation.

The AJP advocates for a paradigm shift in economic models, enabling an inclusion of externalities of the natural world, and a move away from short-term gain to long-term ecological sustainability, prioritising wellbeing over relentless growth, and emphasising the importance of sustainable and future focused change to ensure a balance between human activities and planetary boundaries.

We promote the adoption of circular economy principles, community-led initiatives, and local resilience measures to minimise negative impact on the ecological footprint. We envision a society that measures success, not only by economic metrics, but also by the health of ecosystems, the wellbeing of communities, and the ethical and moral treatment of non-human animals, aligning with a holistic and sustainable approach to living and thriving.

Core Principle

The economy must operate within ecological limits, recognising that infinite growth on a finite planet is impossible. We must transition from individual accumulation to community abundance while ensuring everyone's basic needs are met. This shift directly protects animals by reducing the resource extraction and habitat destruction driven by endless manufacturing, eliminating urban sprawl that fragments wildlife corridors, and decreasing demand for industrial animal agriculture required to sustain high-consumption lifestyles.

Economy Within Ecological Limits

The AJP recognises that infinite economic growth on a finite planet is incompatible with human wellbeing, wildlife protection, ecosystem resilience, and animal welfare. The economy must operate within ecological limits, prioritising community abundance, meeting everyone's basic needs and safeguarding the habitats that sustain nonhuman animals.

Humanity has long exceeded the planet's safe ecological limits. Scientific evidence shows that at least six of the nine planetary boundaries (climate change, biodiversity loss, land-system change, freshwater use, nitrogen and phosphorus cycles, and chemical pollution) are already beyond safe thresholds. This overshoot drives habitat destruction, fragments ecosystems and reduces wildlife to vulnerable populations, while intensifying suffering for farmed animals through industrial, resource-intensive systems.

Transitioning to a post-growth, sufficiency-based economy ensures that resource use stays within planetary limits, protects ecosystems and prioritises the welfare of all sentient beings while meeting human needs.

Key Objectives:

1. Adopt post-growth economic frameworks, replacing GDP with indicators that measure ecosystem health, biodiversity recovery, animal welfare, and human wellbeing.
2. Establish annual resource consumption caps, aligned with planetary regeneration capacity, to prevent habitat destruction and species decline.
3. Mandate corporate environmental and animal welfare impact disclosure, requiring businesses to show supply chains and operations do not contribute to animal suffering.
4. Require large corporations (>$50 million revenue) to deliver measurable positive outcomes for native wildlife and domestic animal welfare, alongside financial performance.

Sharing Economy and Community Abundance

The AJP is committed to creating a society where everyone has access to high-quality shared resources while reducing the environmental destruction caused by excessive private consumption and accumulation. We acknowledge that current economic models promote individual ownership of rarely-used items, driving resource extraction that destroys wildlife habitats while leaving many people unable to access basic amenities. We propose transforming our economy towards private sufficiency and public luxury ensuring everyone has what they need privately while creating magnificent shared spaces and resources that surpass what any individual could afford alone.

Private sufficiency means everyone having secure access to life's essentials: safe housing, nutritious food, healthcare, education, and the resources needed for a dignified life. Public luxury means creating shared amenities so extraordinary that they meet and exceed what is available through private ownership: world-class libraries, community workshops equipped with professional tools, beautiful public gardens, shared vehicles, communal spaces for celebration and creativity.

This approach dramatically reduces environmental pressure while improving quality of life. Instead of millions of households owning power tools used twice yearly, communities share professional-grade equipment available whenever needed. Rather than everyone buying individual cars, communities enjoy access to diverse vehicles, electric cars for daily transport, cargo bikes for local trips, vans for moving house. The result is less environmental destruction with far greater access to high-quality resources. UK example

Internationally, this model is already succeeding. Vienna's social housing provides homes for 60% of residents at below-market rates, while the city's public transport, parks, and cultural facilities are world-renowned. The city demonstrates that prioritising public investment over private accumulation creates both environmental sustainability and exceptional quality of life.

Examples of what this could mean in Aotearoa includes, but is not limited to the following:

- Every person guaranteed secure, affordable housing with private bedrooms and personal space, accommodating different family structures and life stages
- Community kitchens equipped with professional-grade appliances and tools
- Shared gardens, libraries, workshops, and creative spaces in every neighbourhood
- Common rooms for celebration, meetings, and social connection designed for beauty and functionality
- Childcare facilities, study spaces, and quiet zones accessible to all residents
- Comprehensive public transport networks connecting all communities
- Community car-sharing cooperatives with electric vehicles for different needs
- Free or subsidised public transport reducing individual transport costs
- Cycling infrastructure making bike transport safe, convenient, and weather-protected
- Electric cars available for longer journeys and specific transport needs
- Cargo bikes and trailers for local goods transport and family outings
- Specialist vehicles (vans for moving, vehicles adapted for disability access) available through community booking systems
- Maintenance, insurance, and fuel costs shared across communities rather than individual burden
- Fully-equipped maker spaces, repair cafés, and tool libraries in every community
- Skilled staff and volunteers providing training and support for community members

- Integration with local education to teach practical skills and reduce reliance on consumer culture
- Community-owned high-quality printers, scanners, and specialist equipment
- Shared recreational equipment: musical instruments, sports gear, outdoor equipment, exercise facilities
- Technology lending programmes ensuring everyone can access devices when needed
- Community-controlled internet and digital infrastructure prioritising access over profit
- Public art galleries, performance spaces, and cultural venues free for community use
- Community gardens, food forests, and natural spaces designed for both food production and recreation
- Festivals, cultural events, and community celebrations supported by excellent shared infrastructure
- Public facilities designed to highest standards, beautiful, functional, and inspiring
- Universal accessibility ensuring people with disabilities have full access to shared resources
- Programming and events that build community connections and showcase local talent
- Integration with schools to provide children with access to diverse learning opportunities
- Reduced tax rates for worker cooperatives and community-owned enterprises
- Tax advantages for businesses prioritising people, planet, and animals over profit maximisation
- Simplified regulations for community-owned sharing services and cooperative ventures
- Public procurement preferences for cooperatively-owned businesses serving community needs

This approach directly reduces pressure on animals and their habitats. Manufacturing fewer products means less resource extraction destroying wildlife homes. Shared transport reduces urban sprawl that fragments habitats. Community food production can focus on plant-based options, eliminating demand for factory farming while building food security.

When people's essential needs are met through public investment rather than private accumulation, they're less vulnerable to economic pressures that might force them into exploitative employment, including jobs that harm animals. Economic security creates space for making ethical choices about consumption, work, and lifestyle.

The AJP believes that pursuing private sufficiency and public luxury is a transformative approach that can begin now in pilot communities while building towards broader social change. It will create better quality of life with dramatically reduced environmental impact, build the social infrastructure necessary for a cooperative society, and reduce the economic pressures that perpetuate harmful industries while creating abundance through sharing rather than individual accumulation.

Key Objectives:

1. Establish demonstration communities showcasing the private sufficiency, public luxury model with shared facilities and sufficient private space for all residents
2. Invest in world-class public amenities (libraries, transport, workshops, and cultural facilities) that surpass what individuals could access through private ownership

3. Create comprehensive community sharing networks for tools, vehicles, and equipment that reduce manufacturing demand while improving access to high-quality resources
4. Transform urban planning to prioritise shared spaces over individual storage, freeing land for wildlife corridors and community gardens
5. Support cooperative ownership models ensuring communities control their shared resources while building local economies based on cooperation rather than competition
6. Integrate with housing policy to ensure everyone has secure private space while building communities around extraordinary shared amenities that foster connection and reduce environmental impact
7. Establish community land trusts specifically to prevent land speculation that converts wildlife habitat and small-scale plant-based farming into industrial animal agriculture operations.

Circular Economy and Community Resilience

The AJP is committed to fostering sharing economies and circular systems that reduce waste, strengthen communities, and minimise our environmental footprint. We acknowledge that current economic models based on individual ownership and constant consumption drive the resource extraction and habitat destruction that devastate wildlife across Aotearoa New Zealand.

Moving beyond ownership models towards community-based sharing reduces pressure on natural systems whilst building stronger neighbourhoods. When communities share tools, vehicles, and resources, we dramatically reduce the manufacturing demand that destroys habitats for native species. Car sharing alone can remove up to 15 private vehicles from our roads, freeing urban space for green corridors that native birds and insects desperately need.[25]

Community repair initiatives extend product lifecycles, reducing the 252,000 tonnes of e-waste New Zealand generates annually—much of which contains toxic materials harmful to wildlife. Libraries evolved from book repositories to community hubs can become centres for sharing everything from tools to toys, reducing the material throughput that drives environmental degradation.

Research from the Ellen MacArthur Foundation shows circular economy approaches can reduce material extraction by up to 80% while creating more jobs than linear systems. Worker cooperatives focused on repair and reuse create meaningful employment that builds community wealth whilst protecting the environment that sustains all life.

The AJP believes that sharing economies represent an immediately implementable approach to reducing environmental harm whilst strengthening communities. These systems will reduce habitat destruction, support local employment, and create the social infrastructure necessary for building a society that values cooperation over competition.

Key Objectives:

1. Expand nationwide networks of community repair cafés and tool libraries to extend product lifecycles and reduce manufacturing demand
2. Support car-sharing cooperatives to reduce urban vehicle numbers and free land for native habitat corridors
3. Transform library infrastructure into multi-purpose community hubs that facilitate resource sharing and reduce individual consumption
4. Fund worker cooperatives specialising in repair, reuse, and sharing services that create meaningful local employment
5. Create public banking options offering preferential rates for cooperative enterprises focused on plant-based production, animal sanctuary operations and habitat restoration projects
6. Support community ownership of renewable energy systems, ensuring profits from clean energy stay local rather than flowing to extractive corporations that often fund habitat destruction

[25] Transport & Environment. (n.d.). *Does car sharing really reduce car use?* Retrieved October 24, 2025, from https://www.transportenvironment.org/articles/does-car-sharing-really-reduce-car-use